

THE DARK HORSES



While the world focuses on Windows 8 and the ilk, here are some OSes that might just come up from the rear and surprise you. And how!

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The world of technology is one of constant flux. Technology and its effects can be so unpredictable that the big surprise is that we are ever surprised at all. But it happens, and it will continue to. A number of interesting events lie ahead in the coming year and many of them have great potential to disrupt the world of technology – in a good way.

Firefox OS

It was a dark time in 2011 when Google announced that Android 3.0 wouldn't be open source; everyone felt like the open source world lost its biggest poster child. It's all well now that Android is open source again but the lesson learned was that there needs to be an alternative that isn't under the control of one company. Under these conditions Boot 2 Gecko was born, an open source, web standards-based operating

system. The goal wasn't just to have a web-based mobile OS, but also to develop the web standards needed to make such a device viable. The end result is a mobile OS and apps built entirely using HTML, CSS, JavaScript and running on a bare minimum browser instance.

Many a pundit have said that Firefox OS has no chance of competition against the slew of phones running Android and iOS. If you want to make money, you need to make a smartphone that can take on Android and iOS in the first world, but Mozilla, being non-profit, is in the unique position of not worrying about how much money it makes.

Mozilla knows people won't give up their iPhones or Android devices for Firefox OS, but then again, that isn't their audience. They are trying to make a lightweight OS that can run on cheaper phones that Android can't run on. It is a way to bring the smartphone to people who currently can't afford them. This is also why it isn't even launching in the US initially, but Brazil instead.

Firefox OS is one to look out for, even if it might not reach our shores any time soon. But hey, it is opensource and fully hackable! It's possible to run it on a number of Android devices or even the Raspberry Pi.

BlackBerry 10

Everyone knows that BlackBerry hasn't been doing too well, and as is advisable in such situations, RIM is skipping a few version numbers and going straight to BlackBerry 10 or BlackBerry X. Does it have potential though? It just might! It's hard to find a part of the OS that *hasn't* been revamped – or maybe it's easier to say that this is an all new OS. The BlackBerry 10 OS is based on QNX now, features a fresh new UI that has been redesigned from the ground up for better multitasking and

extensive touch and gesture support. The multitasking support on the OS is far ahead of the competition, and more along the lines of webOS and Maemo. Of course it still brings the good old features of BlackBerry (BBM for example), but adds on stuff like audio and video chat for BBM, a social



Leaked screenshot of BlackBerry 10

media hub, an innovative predictive on-screen keyboard, amongst other things.

What's equally important is that BlackBerry 10 also supports many routes of development for app developers. The device supports Qt for its native development path, but also allows packaged web (HTML5) applications, Adobe AIR-based applications and even supports Android applications (such apps need to be repackaged for BlackBerry though). The more paths developers have means more apps for users.

KDE Plasma Active

If you've used Linux there is a strong chance you have heard of KDE. The history of the KDE brand is confusing, while it used to stand for K Desktop Environment, its current avatar – KDE – represents the community that makes the software. The KDE Software Compilation is the product of the KDE community and is an alternative to Gnome and Ubuntu's Unity.



Firefox OS running in a simulator on Windows